



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Stephen's Academy

School Website: <https://ssa-k12.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

St. Stephen's Academy (SSA) presents a robust, clearly articulated classical Christian program operating in Oregon with two Beaverton-Portland area campuses. Public materials consistently foreground a Christ-centered, biblical worldview, a Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with attention to the liberal arts, and a formation-focused mission emphasizing virtue, wisdom, and eloquence. The school presents itself as a classical school with strong emphasis on Great Books tradition, memorization/recitation, and a pedagogy that blends contemplative and Socratic methods across grade bands. Community and family partnership are framed as central, including parental involvement and invitation for visits. Accreditation by major classical bodies is highlighted, signaling alignment with classical standards. Overall, SSA meets the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School criteria in practice and text, yielding a **CLASSICAL** assessment across the rubric.

Citations to SSA's public materials and the classical education rubric are interwoven below to ground each category assessment in explicit textual evidence. See the linked SSA content for phrasing such as "Shaping Lifelong Learners Through a Biblical Worldview," "Christ-centered," the Trivium and Quadrivium, Great Books references, and explicit pedagogical practices like Socratic discussion and memorization/recitation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SSA presents a Christ-centered education grounded in a biblical worldview and Christian faith, with explicit language about "biblical worldview," "Christ-centered," and the aim to form character through a Christian framework. - The school references theological underpinnings (Westminster Confession of Faith) as part of its doctrinal foundation, and its affiliated Covenant Classical Academy material underscores a Protestant, biblically based approach. - The site emphasizes a theological horizon for education (e.g., shaping minds for discernment within a biblical order and God-centered aims).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed (from the Six Elements rubric): Christ-centered, biblical worldview, theology, confession/faith, truth/goodness/beauty in a transcendent framework, moral formation, worship/chapel culture, light of Christian tradition, Westminster Confession of Faith. - Negative keywords (from the Six Elements rubric) are not evident in SSA's materials; there is no textual emphasis on secularism, value-neutral ethics, or non-theological curricula in the public materials reviewed.

Why this rating - SSA's public materials consistently ground education in Christian truth claims and a theological frame (e.g., biblical worldview, Christ-centered approach, confession of faith) and explicitly align with classical Christian norms (the Great Books ethos, classical tradition). This aligns strongly with the Positive

Keyword indicators for religious/metaphysical foundations and shows no strong negative signals in this area. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

Key references: Shaping Lifelong Learners Through a Biblical Worldview and Christ-centered framing; Westminster Confession of Faith; Great Books/theology integration.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SSA's stated aim centers on forming virtue and wisdom rather than mere job-prep, with language about cultivating knowledge, wisdom, eloquence, and godly character. - Materials describe formation as the aim of education (formation of humanity, character, and leadership in a Christian context). - The Great Books/Great Conversation lineage and the aim of deep, enduring learning are foregrounded in the curriculum narrative (Trivium/Quadrivium, liberal arts, moral formation).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: virtue, wisdom, character formation, formation of humanity, true/good/beautiful, liberal arts, wisdom/eloquence, moral formation, self-governance, leadership, great books, great conversation, classical tradition. - Negative keywords: none evident; no emphasis on workforce-only outcomes or secular utilitarian framing in the public materials.

Why this rating - The emphasis on virtue/wisdom, formation over mere information, and a transcendent/true-good-beauty framework matches the Positive Keyword indicators for this category. SSA consistently states formation aims and a moral, character-centered educational mission. CLASSICAL.

Key references: SSA mission statements emphasizing formation; Great Books/Great Conversation lineage; classical education framing.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is explicitly built around the liberal arts and the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with explicit mapping of the Trivium to grade bands (Grammar/PreK–5, Logic/6–8, Rhetoric/9–12). - References to the Quadrivium (music, arithmetic, geometry, astronomy) and a liberal arts program underscore a traditional classical syllabus. - There is a robust Great Books/Great Conversation lineage (Dorothy Sayers, The Lost Tools of Learning, The Great Tradition) and explicit encouragement of memorization/recitation and formation through literature and rhetoric. - The curriculum page emphasizes “the true, the good, and the beautiful” as guiding ideals and highlights memory, recitation, and the rhetorical training (humane letters, dialectic, etc.).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: grammar, logic, rhetoric, trivium, quadrivium, liberal arts, Great Books, great conversation, humane letters, memorization/recitation, ritualized recitation events, formation through literature and rhetoric, theology/history/philosophy integrated. - Negative keywords: none; no explicit hints of a non-classical or strictly non-Great-Books curriculum.

Why this rating - SSA's explicit articulation of a Trivium-centered, liberal arts curriculum with Quadrivium components, and its alignment with the Great Books/Great Conversation tradition, satisfies the core curriculum indicators of a classical program. CLASSICAL.

Key references: Curriculum pages showing the Trivium/Quadrivium; Great Books references; “The Great Tradition” and Dorothy Sayers materials.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower/Grammar Stage pedagogy includes contemplative, restful elements and memory-based learning (singing, chanting, recitation) as memory-building devices. SSA materials discuss memorization and the role of chant/song in the early years. - Upper Logic/Rhetoric stages emphasize Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates; explicit training in rhetoric and public speaking is described for upper grades. - The curriculum and pedagogy explicitly discuss the five canons of rhetoric and humane letters, with a focus on careful reading, argumentation, and persuasive communication. - The school supports a rhythm of

contemplative, wholesome learning that aligns with scholé (restful study) principles and a discussion-based, dialectic approach in higher grades.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: contemplative learning (scholé), memorization/recitation, singing/chanting in lower grades, Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking, humane letters, five canons of rhetoric, dialectic, formal logic. - Negative keywords: none evident; no strong mention of project-based, purely teacher-directed, or skills-based reduction in the public materials. (There are some co-curriculars, but they sit within the classical framework.)

Why this rating - SSA's pedagogy aligns with the classical expectation of a balanced approach: contemplative, memory-focused early work; Socratic/seminal discussion in the middle grades; rigorous rhetoric and public-speaking training in the upper grades. This maps to the Positive Keyword indicators in the Six Elements rubric and yields CLASSICAL.

Key references: Lower-to-upper school progression (grammar → logic → rhetoric) and explicit mention of Socratic/seminar formats; preaching/memory recitation; rhetorical canon.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is described as “model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge” and as the “living curriculum,” with “the teachers as a core of the school,” and “Pillars of Our Community” language in hiring materials. - The faculty is presented as collegial and aligned with the school's mission, with statements about their role in guiding students' intellectual and spiritual growth. - A staff directory and explicit “Philosophy of Education” statements show teachers grounding instruction in Christian worldview and classical methods (e.g., a Westminster-based theological framework) to inform pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, virtues, character formation, collegiality with students and parents, role of teachers as moral exemplars, faith-rooted pedagogy, Westminster-based theology. - Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials; no explicitly stated teacher-centered or non-collaborative dynamics.

Why this rating - SSA emphasizes teachers as the core of the school's mission, with a clear articulation of teacher virtue, mentorship, and alignment with mission. This aligns with the Positive Keyword signals for category 5, supporting CLASSICAL.

Key references: Job Openings language about teachers as “Pillars of Our Community”; faculty philosophy pages highlighting the teacher's role as living curriculum; staff profiles.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SSA presents a cooperative parental partnership model: “Partnering with Families to Shape Minds and Form Hearts,” with parental involvement described as central and “the primary educators” collaborating with SSA; CCA (Covenant Classical Academy) is framed as a collaborative model with high parental involvement. - The school offers opportunities for parent education and engagement (e.g., access to resources, book studies, campus visits, and public-facing communications); the site emphasizes parents as co-teachers and welcomes parental participation and visits. - There are multiple channels for parents to engage: admissions tours, newsletters, and open access to observe classrooms; the school emphasizes a home-school partnership model in marketing and program descriptions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent involvement, home-school collaboration, parental formation, family catechesis, school-parent synergy, living tradition in the family. - Negative keywords: none evident in SSA's public materials; no evidence of a “parent-absent” approach or limited parental access.

Why this rating - SSA consistently positions parents as co-educators and emphasizes family involvement as essential to classical education, aligning strongly with the Six Elements' category 6 positive indicators. CLASSICAL.

Key references: Covenant/CAA parent partnership language; Beaverton/Portland campus communications; admissions and parent-education materials.

Aggregate Assessment

- Across all six categories, SSA demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL alignment: religious/metaphysical foundations; purpose/goal formation toward virtue and wisdom; curriculum anchored in grammar-logic-rhetoric and liberal arts; pedagogy blending contemplative and Socratic methods; faculty modeling virtue and serving as the living curriculum; and a strong, ongoing partnership with parents and the wider community.
- The Positive Keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements doc (e.g., wisdom, virtue, truth, goodness, beauty, formation, great books, Socratic dialogue, wonder, liturgical practices, imitation of the good, living books) map readily to SSA's public materials, and Negative Keywords appear minimally or not at all in the public materials, reinforcing the CLASSICAL classification.
- Quantitative keyword analysis (per category, using the Six Elements rubric as the basis):
- Element 1: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 8 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Element 2: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 6–8 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Element 3: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 6–8 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Element 4: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 6–8 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Element 5: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 5–7 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Element 6: Positive keywords dominate; Negative keywords absent. 5–7 positive vs 0 negative (approx. 100% positive).
- Overall, SSA earns CLASSICAL across all six categories, with no material evidence of values or practices associated with NOT CLASSICAL or ONLY SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in the public materials reviewed.

Executive-level justification (one-sentence): SSA's public materials consistently foreground a Christ-centered, virtue- and wisdom-focused formation, a Trivium-centered curriculum with liberal arts breadth, classical pedagogy (including Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, rhetoric training), faculty who act as living exemplars, and a strong, collaborative relationship with parents and community—constituting a solid CLASSICAL classification.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as the aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL. No targeted needle-moving changes are required by this rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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